

The Making of Cha

Every member of the Indian team had something to prove. Youthful zest, a risk-taking captain and a sense of

■ By Sharda Ugra in Johannesburg

It began on a bus at Johannesburg's Oliver Tambo airport. A group of cricketers climbed on and sized each other up, some coming in weary from a tour of England, others from India, straining at the bit. A messy mix of 15 and their minders, some old, most new, some on borrowed time and others feeling a little blue. Two weeks later, after this first chaotic "team meeting", the Indian cricket team got back on the bus again. To a man, drained in mind

and body, but light of spirit, they travelled not with their individual worries from a fortnight ago, but with a single silver trophy packed in their luggage.

When Mahendra Singh Dhoni's men returned home with the ICC World Twenty20 title, they gave 21st-century India its own 1983, exactly like Kapil's Devils had done to an older generation. This was not a triumph remembered through the haze of history and black and white nostalgia. This was victory transmitted through a billion pounding hearts like an electric surge, in the here

and the now, under lights and cameras, in widescreen panoramic colour, in the fastest version of cricket ever known. This was redemption for a lousy Caribbean World Cup. This was, with everything else, very seriously cool.

It was also utterly unexpected. With a single T20 international among them, no head coach and a rookie as captain India were expected to cave in to canny T20 campaigners like England, South Africa and Australia. But the lack of T20 experience meant Indians were never in danger of over-thinking or

